one and declared reverence to fire to be superior to every other kind of worship'. They taught the Padshah the rituals of their religion and Akbar decreed that the sacred fire be maintained at Fatehpur Sikri, under the charge of Abu'l Fazl, and kept eternally burning. For 'though illiterate', agreed the Jesuits, '[Akbar] loved to hear discussions on points of theology and philosophy and with an open mind, listened to any man learned in the law, whether he was Parsee or Hindu or Christian'. Akbar had heard of the renown of the Jain priest, Hiravijaya Suri. According to Jain folklore, Akbar happened to witness a religious procession celebrating six months of fasting by a Jain monk Champa and was intrigued. The Padshah immediately sent two prominent Jain citizens of Agra, Bhanu Kalyan and Singh Ramji, to summon Hiravijaya to the Mughal court. He also issued farmans to the Governor of Gujarat to make all the necessary arrangements for a comfortable journey for the Jain monk.

As for the Christians, Akbar 'always seemed not only to favour them, but to heap honours upon them in his desire to show his affection towards them. For when 'they saluted him, which they did with uncovered heads, he answered with a nod and a bright smile… When a council was being held… he used to make them sit beside him. He shook hands with them cordially and familiarly…. Several times he paced up and down with his arm round Rudolf 's shoulders…. He wished the priests to be sharers of his inmost thoughts, both in good and ill fortune—no common mark of love and kindness'. The same casualness and ease of manner that Rafiuddin Shirazi had been amazed by all those years before, when he had struggled to recognize the Padshah of Hindustan as the youth leaning against a friend, Akbar now demonstrated with the Jesuits. Grasping them affectionately by the arm, he would listen to their disquisitions, head slightly tilted as was his wont. The charm of his personality made them believe that, in that instant, Akbar's attention was entirely theirs. Acquaviva's ardent desire to convert this extraordinary Muslim king and save his soul never abated. 'It was remarkable,' admitted Monserrate, 'with what zeal he longed that [Akbar] should be converted from a wicked life to the worship of God.' And when Akbar understood Acquaviva's motivation, continued Monserrate, 'he began to love Rudolf warmly, not because he had any idea of becoming a Christian, or had much of an opinion of our religion but because (as he used to say himself), knowing that Rudolf regarded Christianity as the best of all